

Volunteer Experience Reflection

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Volunteering is an integral feature of social work, serving as a bridge between theoretical knowledge and practical application. For this assignment, I had the opportunity to volunteer at Transitions Housing—an organization dedicated to supporting individuals experiencing homelessness and related challenges. My primary role involved distributing food during lunch and dinner hours. While my interactions were mainly with staff and fellow volunteers, this experience offered valuable insights into the operational aspects of social services and underscored the importance of ethical practices—such as obtaining and maintaining consent. I was required to sign various forms and waivers that outlined consent policies, ensuring the protection of clients at Transitions. In this paper, I will reflect on my volunteering experience, exploring the skills I practiced and the values I operationalized.

Experience

Transitions Housing provides shelter and comprehensive support services to individuals experiencing homelessness, focusing on transitional housing solutions. The organization serves a diverse population, encompassing individuals from various backgrounds, including families, veterans, and those with disabilities. During my volunteer experience, I assisted in plating and distributing meals during lunch and dinner hours. My responsibilities include a variety of tasks, such as rolling plastic-ware, plating food, serving meals, and cleaning the kitchen and serving area afterward. Although I had limited direct interactions with clients, I engaged with the dedicated staff and fellow volunteers—some of whom were also clients staying at Transitions and working for pay—who were committed to the organization's mission. This collaborative environment fostered a sense of teamwork and community. The brief interactions I did have with clients were positive, allowing me to practice active listening and employ open-ended questions,

such as inquiring about how their day was going. Many clients expressed gratitude for the meals, and I was surprised to learn that a significant number of them had disabilities, highlighting the diverse needs within the community.

Reflection on Interpersonal and Communication Skills Practiced

While my role primarily involved physical tasks, I also had the opportunity to practice essential interpersonal skills through my interactions with staff, fellow volunteers, and clients. Working in a kitchen and food service environment necessitates clear and effective communication to ensure smooth operations and service delivery. The requirement to sign consent forms not only reinforced my understanding of ethical communication but also provided a practical example of the importance of transparency in social services. Additionally, staff and volunteers were required to wear masks and personal protective equipment (PPE), which limited some forms of non-verbal communication, such as smiling. To adapt, I focused on other aspects of the SOLER technique, maintaining an open posture, making eye contact, and nodding to convey attentiveness. I also used a friendly tone to project empathy and warmth, fostering a supportive atmosphere, even in a challenging context.

Identification & Reflection on Social Work Core Values Operationalized

Throughout my volunteering experience, I operationalized several core values outlined by the National Association of Social Workers. The value of service was evident in my commitment to providing meals and support to those in need. Although my direct interactions with clients were limited, I recognized the significance of my role in contributing to the overall mission of the organization. The process of signing waivers and discussing consent underscored the value of dignity and worth of the person, emphasizing the importance of respecting individuals' rights and ensuring they are informed about both my participation and theirs. My

interactions with staff highlighted the importance of human relationships, as collaboration was essential for our collective success.

Analysis of Challenges, Impact, and Growth

While I did not encounter significant challenges during my time at Transitions Housing, the experience profoundly shaped my understanding of social services. Although my interactions with clients were limited, the environment illuminated the complexities surrounding homelessness and the critical role organizations play in supporting vulnerable populations. I developed a deeper appreciation for the importance of every role within the organization, recognizing how even the smallest logistical tasks contribute significantly to the mission. This experience enhanced my communication skills and fostered a stronger sense of teamwork and collaboration, which will be useful as I continue to develop in a social work environment.

Volunteer Certification

This is to certify that Annabelle Woody has completed 6 hours of
volunteering with Transit City Housing.

Name

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Mel-Lucina

Date:

10/30/24